

Quinnipiac Students and Faculty Address Lack of Communication from Administration

BY MATTOX WARD

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Hamden, Connecticut — Calls for improved communication are echoing across Quinnipiac University, with students and faculty citing recent events as evidence of a communication gap with administration.

Throughout the 2023-24 school year, multiple incidents have fueled concerns about transparency and responsiveness from university officials, leaving many members of the Quinnipiac community feeling uninformed and unheard.

On January 17, a major flood struck the Mountainview Residence Hall three days before spring move-in day, leaving many students' belongings damaged and some still waiting on compensation months later. Repairs took upwards of three weeks in the most severe cases, and the cause of the flood still remains a mystery.

Alex Nicastro, a first-year film, TV, and media arts major, lives in the main suite affected by the sprinkler malfunction. He says that he found out about the flood through social media and later received unclear updates from his residential assistant through the messaging app GroupMe. He also states that the response from Quinnipiac administration during the event was minimal and not very coordinated.

“They could have told us more about what was happening,” Nicastro said. “The university was very vague about the whole thing, not telling us what specifically was damaged. I only got information when I came back to campus from break. They could have also given us a set date on when we could move back into Mountainview. We received three different times for when we could move back.”

His suitemate Antonio Shippee Lopez explains that he learned about the flooding through a Snapchat story posted by a student-run Quinnipiac 2027 page before being notified by the university. As rumors floated around the building regarding what caused the flood, it left students like Shippee Lopez confused and concerned while away from school.

“I wish the university was more clear on what was happening,” Shippee Lopez said. “Cleanup was slow and it made moving across the floor a pain.”

Hilary Fussell Sisco, professor and founding chairwoman of the strategic communication department at Quinnipiac University, says the communication from administration fell short, not just for the people affected, but for all residents in the building.

“If information isn't open and public, people will make up information to fill the gaps,” Fussell Sisco said. “The reason we have rumors is because if something doesn't connect for me, point A to Z, I'm gonna fill it in for myself...If Mountainview floods, and I only talk to the people that are affected in the rooms, and I don't

talk to the entire dorm, that other group is going to feel like, ‘Well, why was I left out of the conversation?’”

Concerns have also been raised about the university's handling of the over-acceptance of students in the 2023-24 school year, resulting in over 60 students being placed in converted study lounges for their dorm rooms.

Kira Diaz, a first-year student at Quinnipiac, says she learned less than two months before moving in that she would be living in a study lounge. This significantly impacted how many items she could bring to school, as some study lounges were housing six or more students. However, Diaz was fortunate enough to share her room with only two other people.

When asked if Quinnipiac should have taken a different approach to make living in a study lounge more manageable, Diaz said “In my case, no, but in many other cases, the university should have done better for people living with a full study lounge.”

Hilary Fussell Sisco, familiar with the challenges of over-enrollment, discusses Virginia Tech's similar experience in 2019. The university, where she earned her undergraduate degree, was forced to house students in hotels due to over-acceptance.

“I think there has to be real clear parameters of what ‘housing’ means,” Fussell Sisco said. “If ‘housing’ means that housing is provided, and there's no capacity, then that has to be super clear...We are [also] in this state of transition...the new dorm [The Grove] is being built, and there's always a little squeeze in growth

before it happens. So saying that we're in the squeeze and hoping people stick along for the ride...I think that's part of it, too.”

Fussell Sisco also mentions the importance of transparency on the human psyche and how not doing so can “psychologically feel like we're being kept out of the loop.”

“If people feel like you're not being transparent with them, there's a level of distrust that starts,” Fussell Sisco said. “Then if you have a level of distrust, you don't believe anything I say...there's always this feeling that something's being held back,” something she explains is especially prevalent during moments of tragedy.

Earlier this year, a student attending Quinnipiac died by suicide, and due to private reasons, this information was never brought to the students’ or faculty members’ attention. Another event occurred this semester when a professor died from undisclosed complications, and their colleagues were not made aware of the situation.

Fussell Sisco, who also specializes in crisis communication, highlights the importance of navigating the fine line between transparency and privacy in these sensitive situations.

“With a student, it's especially sensitive...There's the wishes sometimes of family members, which can be in conflict with basic information...because there's sensitivity to it. That can be triggering to somebody or that can be really upsetting...Honestly I don't know if there's always a super right way because I think there's always going to be some kind of feelings involved in that kind of situation.”

Fussell Sisco also addresses the university's main concern with disclosing such information to the community, mentioning the possibility of "copycat suicide." However, she suggests alternative approaches for the university to ensure the community feels informed and supported during such tragedies.

"I felt like that was not a great argument because a more...public sentiment would have been more empathetic...I think it should be just a public statement that does not mention why or how, but does mention an unexpected passing of one of our members of our community. That's it...and then move on. I think there's the risk that if people then dig deeper to find out on their own...it can spur feelings in people, and that's a concern. So then maybe you make sure that RAs are aware of that and counselors are aware of that."

As the school year comes to an end, Fussell Sisco pinpoints a key issue at Quinnipiac: a lack of transparency and consistent information. She believes that a more unified communication approach would not only keep everyone informed, but also create a stronger relationship between students and professors.

"I think they need to figure out how to communicate broadly with all different types of audiences with one voice. I think what happens is we do a lot of segmented communication...I want there to be a way for us all to get the same information or have access to the same information...When things happen that I don't know about, I find about it through my students...For me in that moment, it would've been helpful if I could pull it up on the screen and walk through it with the students."

As Quinnipiac University strives to be "a community that embraces positive change," incorporating a more open and cohesive communication strategy could help lead to a stronger sense of community, aligning with the university's mission of "inclusive excellence, kindness and generosity of spirit."

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Interview Subjects:

- **Hilary Fussell Sisco** / Professor of Strategic Communication, Founding Chair of the Strategic Communication Department at Quinnipiac University
- **Alex Nicastro** / Quinnipiac University ('26, '27) / Film, TV, and Media Arts Major
- **Antonio Shippee Lopez** / Quinnipiac University ('26, '27) / Film, TV, and Media Arts Major
- **Kira Diaz** / Quinnipiac University ('27) Student